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DEFINING THE COLOMBIAN CINEMATIC SOUND: EXPLORING A NATIONAL IDENTITY FOR FILM MUSIC IN A GLOBAL CONTEXT

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Abstract

This research project investigates how a contemporary cinematographic sonic identity can be constructed by integrating traditional Colombian organology, regional musical practices, and narratives of shared historical experience into hybrid film scoring workflows. Grounded in qualitative, practice-based research, the study examines the translation of socio-historical memory—specifically forced displacement and the rupture of territorial identity as documented in Alfredo Molano's *Desterrados: crónicas del desarraigo*—into an autonomous dramatic musical language. Departing from conventional folkloric literalism and exoticism, local instruments (such as the *gaita*, *tiple*, *marimba de chonta*, and regional percussion) were explored through extended techniques, audio processing, sound design, and metric/timbral deconstruction, articulating them with orchestral writing and synthesizers. The practical artifact comprises an original eight-movement hybrid suite (*Desterrados*) recorded with a 52-piece orchestra and mixed choir, alongside its implementation across diverse audiovisual media, including the Colombian social drama short film *Pedacito de Tela* and foreign visual media. The findings demonstrate that emancipating indigenous sonorities from strict geographical and historical ties yields a versatile, emotionally resonant palette capable of depicting universal psychological states in contemporary cinema, offering an alternative to saturated commercial sample libraries and establishing a dialogue between local heritage and global screen narratives.

Keywords: Film scoring, Acoustic hybridization , Colombian traditional music, sonic identity, practice-based research, audiovisual narrative, uprootedness, historical memory.

Introduction

Film music composition is a discipline in constant transformation that, through the years, has transitioned from the diversity and heterogeneity of formats during silent cinema, passing through the grandiloquent and epic sound of orchestras, to current hybridization, with its vast range of treatments and sonic possibilities. The changes experienced in film music composition attend to the historical context of each era; for example, when television arrived, attendance in theaters was reduced and, in the same way, there was a shift from having giant orchestras to jazz ensembles and other formats of related dimensions. It is significant to

verify that the size of the television screen was reduced and, likewise, the size of the musical ensemble decreased.

In the eighties, with the boom of electronic sounds, music took an important turn: major productions began to use synthesizers in response to the technological advances of the period. As Hill (2017, p. xiv) points out:

"big changes are occurring in the way we receive and appreciate 'serious music' [...] As in all periods of rapid change, there are those who want to ride the change and those who want to buck it, and a whole lot who feel an uneasy ambivalence."

Currently, in an attempt to be part of this change, it is observed that productions seek a unique sonic identity. In the face of so many possibilities for composing, how can we create a new musical voice? Proposing an unprecedented sonic universe seems a titanic task; almost a requirement reserved for geniuses, for great masters of music with years of experience, experimentation, and marked rebelliousness. Nevertheless, in an industry in constant transformation, where supporting the narrative requires finding a singular acoustic footprint, we composers are summoned to innovate and propose.

What resources can we make use of to answer this question? It could be said that one of Beethoven's most disruptive proposals was the structural transformation of the symphony: he doubled the duration of the standard form, made the development of sonata form more complex, and introduced the expanded coda. Likewise, Copland (1986, pp. 61–62) states that "Debussy, one of the most instinctive musicians who have ever existed, was the first composer of our time who dared to make his ear the sole judge of what was harmonically right," pointing out that this gesture was sufficient to "sweep away all the theories of harmonic science previously professed."

Now then, how can we innovate? Will this process be linked to a rupture in the formal realm, as in Beethoven, or to a harmonic revolution, as in Debussy? Is it related to form or rather to harmony?

Let us contemplate other examples from common practice; Ross (2007, p. 132) highlights the radical vision of Edgard Varèse when seeking a music constructed from acoustic totality: "I became a sort of diabolic Parsifal, searching not for the Holy Grail but the bomb that would make the musical world explode and thereby let in all sounds, sounds which up to now—and

even today—have been called noises." It is possible to discuss all dimensions of music and the transformations they have experienced throughout history; in this case of Varèse, Ross reflects on timbre. Perhaps sonic identity can be achieved through dynamics or orchestration (the latter understood as the blending of new timbres and not necessarily circumscribed to the traditional orchestra); perhaps through rhythm or silence, or is it perchance outside any musical dimension conceived until now?

Let us see some examples of this evolution in the cinematographic medium. In the silent era, not having synchronized sound, productions made use of diverse formats or a solo piano to maintain the audience's attention; it was natural to resort to live music, given that it constituted the only sound source available. This dynamic was maintained from the beginnings of cinema until the end of the twenties. Starting in 1930, with the arrival of synchronized sound on celluloid, the major studios had the opportunity to form their own music departments and have full orchestras at their disposal. This characterized the Golden Age of Hollywood, a period in which fundamental figures such as Max Steiner or Erich Wolfgang Korngold stood out.

Up to this point it becomes evident that the transition toward sound cinema did not imply a simple growth in the dimensions of the ensemble—given that in the silent period large-format scores and full orchestras already coexisted in the main theaters—, but rather a structural reconfiguration of musical function. Following the initial debate in the first years of sound cinema regarding the need to justify music on screen based on diegetic sources, the orchestration of the 1930s had to reinvent itself in order to integrate within the tripartite sound hierarchy, coexisting with and yielding space to dialogues and sound effects.

In subsequent decades, particularly in the forties, the first significant timbral changes were observed. Early electronic alternatives emerged, such as the theremin and the novachord, which broke the exclusively acoustic character of the traditional orchestra. These timbres began to be closely associated with intrigue and suspense. In this stage, change was once again directly related to the dimensions and configuration of the ensemble.

The pop era emerged toward the 1960s. Because resident studio orchestras were reduced for economic reasons, scores structured around pop and rock songs gained relevance, as did jazz groups and smaller-scale orchestral ensembles. These groups operated independently, unlike the stable orchestras established in the thirties. This phenomenon extended throughout the

following decades until the eighties and, from there on, development continued to be oriented toward the timbral and the hybrid. In this regard, Cooke (2008, p. 473) explains that "the trend towards the fusion of symphonic and synthesized materials became increasingly dominant in the 1990s, when technological advances allowed an unprecedented degree of sophistication in the seamless integration of acoustic and electronic soundscapes."

However, in an era marked by the dizzying advance of artificial intelligence, orchestral hybridization, and sound synthesis linked to sound design, space has also opened up for an alternative within the evolution of film music: the implementation of unconventional, historical, and indigenous instruments originating from diverse regional traditions.

Multiple contemporary examples exist, such as the use of traditional percussions in various films or recent cases such as *Dune* (dir. Denis Villeneuve), where Hans Zimmer seeks to represent the vastness of a desert environment. This practice does not turn out to be entirely unprecedented; the inclusion of vernacular instruments in cinema is clearly traced back to the nineties in works such as *Aladdin* (mus. Alan Menken) and *The Lion King* (mus. Hans Zimmer). Likewise, one observes the revival of historically reconstructed instruments, such as the aulos and the Greek lyre, used in Christopher Nolan's epic *Odyssey*, where the romantic orchestra traditionally associated with productions about the Trojan cycle was dispensed with. This phenomenon also manifests itself in the realm of video games, as in *The Witcher* (based on the literary work by Andrzej Sapkowski), where traditional instruments from Polish folklore are incorporated. Nevertheless, upon examining these cases, it is observed that the use of such sonorities maintains a direct correspondence with a specific era or geographic enclave. While this contributes an indubitable timbral richness, the following question arises: in what way could these resources be used in any cinematographic genre, regardless of the era or the spatial context in which the narrative unfolds?

A representative case is that of Argentine composer Gustavo Santaolalla, based from an early age in Los Angeles and producer of several of the most emblematic albums of rock in Spanish before entering the cinematographic and video game medium. His sonic language, of a minimalist cut and deeply rooted in South American folklore, aroused marked interest in the audiovisual industry. His soundtrack for the video game *The Last of Us* constitutes one of the most notable examples: there he resorts to an austere instrumentation, of subtle textures and memorable melodic motifs, through an unconventional approach. The plot of the video game is not set in Latin America nor does it relate to its cultural contexts; it is a

post-apocalyptic science fiction narrative centered on the emotional impact of grief and filial loss in the face of a global viral crisis.

The main theme is instrumented on ronroco—an Andean chordophone of Bolivian origin—over a 6/8 meter characteristic of various genres of the Latin American musical tradition. The rhythmic pattern emphasizes the first five beats of the measure, which generates a syncopation and a singular groove. This demonstrates that this type of timbral sources can emancipate itself from geographic or historicist ties: by stripping themselves of exoticist readings, they constitute autonomous aesthetic proposals within a renewed acoustic hybridization. We consider that this creative approach represents a fertile alternative for the future of cinematographic musical language.

1. Objectives

Problem Question

In what way does the contemporary intervention and processing of traditional Colombian organology allow for the construction of a cinematographic timbral palette such that its textural and emotional qualities become intelligible and effective for any international audiovisual audience?

Objectives

1. To analyze the use of traditional instruments in Colombian cinematography, examining their transition from a strictly folkloric function toward a more abstract, psychological, and modern dimension.
2. To design a hybrid sonic palette that articulates local folkloric instruments with orchestra, synthesizers, and sound design, integrating them into a suite inspired by the stories about the Colombian armed conflict collected in the literary work *Desterrados: crónicas del desarraigo*, by Alfredo Molano Bravo.
3. To evaluate this sonic identity in the international context, detaching traditional instruments from their context, to establish their narrative and emotional impact in global productions.

1.1 Justification

This project investigates how a Colombian cinematographic sonic identity can be constructed through the translation of historical memory, regional musical practices, and narratives of displacement into a hybrid and contemporary compositional language for visual media. The central conceptual source of the project is *Desterrados: Crónicas del desarraigo*, by Alfredo Molano, a literary work that documents the human, territorial, and emotional consequences of forced displacement in Colombia. Instead of approaching Colombian sonic identity solely through instrumentation, rhythm, or recognizable folkloric references, this project proposes that national musical identity is also grounded in historical experience, collective trauma, geography, memory, and the fracturing of regional cultures caused by violence. Through a combination of research, analysis, composition, orchestration, and audiovisual application, the project will examine how the regional and emotional dimensions of *Desterrados* can be transformed into an original cinematographic sonic universe. This sonic universe will draw upon Colombian film music, traditional regional sonorities, oral memory, contemporary orchestration, electroacoustic practice, sound design, and hybrid production workflows. Within this framework, the research will be articulated with an analysis of Colombian cinema and its historical approaches to themes of territory, violence, displacement, memory, rurality, and resilience. The project will compare traditional uses of direct folkloric references and politically charged musical gestures with more recent approaches grounded in psychological abstraction, electroacoustic sound, austere orchestration, and hybrid textures. This contrast will allow for defining how film music in Colombia has represented regional and social realities, and how a new compositional language can expand and enrich such practices. The practical creative result will be an audiovisual and musical portfolio divided into two main artistic dimensions. The first will be an original suite of approximately twenty minutes of music inspired by *Desterrados*. This suite will function as a sonic accompaniment to the book and as the primary laboratory for developing the hybrid Colombian sonic identity. The second will be the application of this same sonic language to a selected international short film, testing whether a musical language rooted in Colombian historical experience can remain narratively coherent, emotionally effective, and cinematographically adaptable within a foreign audiovisual context. Therefore, the project transitions from the literary source toward sonic identity, and from sonic identity toward visual media application. This structure allows the project to remain grounded in Colombian history while responding directly to the demands of contemporary international film scoring practice. The final artifact will be

produced under a shared Colombian cultural framework. Compositorio, a Colombian company that produces music for audiovisual media, will function as the production model through which the artistic direction of the project, workflow organization, the orchestration process, recording preparation, hybrid production, quality control, and final delivery will be managed. The project seeks to generate not only academic research, but also a professional proof of concept of a Colombian cinematographic sonic identity capable of operating at the intersection between local memory, contemporary composition, and international audiovisual narrative.

2. Methodology

2.1 Methodological Approach

For the execution of this project, qualitative research was chosen, due to the fact that it seeks to understand and interpret historical, cultural, territorial events and personal situations in order to translate them into a language: the soundtrack. Rather than opting for quantitative research, we focus on examining the historical memory of our country: in what way it has been projected across different cinematographic productions, how music is made in the different regions of Colombia, and how these elements nurture, inspire, and inform our process of creating a sonic identity. We acknowledge that the interpretation of texts and audiovisual material is not neutral, which is why it must be examined in a reflective manner. The project arises from questions traversed by our own subjectivity, from a critical interpretation of our history, from our cultural sensitivity, and our professional experience to interpret literature and image. The artifact adopts, furthermore, a practice-based research methodology, since composition constitutes the final product and is one of the primary methods of inquiry. The creation of sketches, improvisations, timbral experiments, mockups, orchestrations, and recordings will allow testing different ways of translating concepts such as territory, memory, uprootedness, violence, grief, and resilience into specific musical materials that we will explain further on. It could be said that the project arises from a constant laboratory filled with practical musical experiments, both in live concerts, in improvisation studios with other musicians, in DAWs with multiple mockups, through revisions by supervisors, recordings, and a final synchronization. The developed sonic material will be presented in three contexts: the first is the suite inspired by the text *Desterrados*, testing our capacity for the non-stereotypical integration of Colombian music materials and the adaptation of the perspective of experiencing uprootedness in a context that

can be applied to the audiovisual realm. Subsequently, experiments were carried out with the sonic findings of the short film *Pedacito de tela*, and finally, the adaptation of these sonic explorations to two international projects was realized. In this composition map, we can notice that we move from the self to the other, from personal stories and own experiences that can be captured musically in one way to stories scarcely related to our culture and territory, from which we take elements that can become attractive and innovative and apply them to a different medium.

This approach meant that every musical decision had to be justified. It was no longer enough for an instrument or a rhythm to "sound Colombian": we needed to understand where it came from, what relationship it had with the investigated material, and what narrative function it fulfilled within the work.

2.2 Historical, Literary, and Territorial Research

2.2.1 The Armed Conflict in Colombia

The first question one may ask is: is it necessary to speak about the armed conflict in Colombia to create a musical work that reflects Colombian sonic identity? Definitely not; Colombian musical identity is much broader and more diverse, and cannot be reduced solely to violence. However, there are two reasons why we decided to speak about it in this project. The first reason lies in the fact that, even without experiencing it directly, its consequences have permeated our families and communities; no one can remain apart from it, and in one way or another it traverses us as artists. For this reason, we recognize its influence on the way we interpret territory, on the cultural memory of our country, and on our own identity. The second reason is that the conflict has occupied a leading and constant place in our cinema, and therefore in the music that has been created to accompany these stories. In these films, composers have been able to portray fear, loss, displacement, resilience, and memory. Among other things, they have portrayed the feeling behind the events that the war has left us. By studying these two points and relating them, we realize that cinema and music in Colombia have created sonic imaginaries around the conflict over approximately the last 70 years. Now then, the conflict in Colombia has many nuances, places, and specific events, so we have decided to focus on one of the most powerful: Uprootedness. Forced displacement does not simply mean moving or changing locations, but cutting completely any link with one's land for one's own safety and family safety, with one's entire community and the way of life that

has been built. As the Constitutional Court points out, "displacement generates an uprootedness [...] because [the person] is separated from everything that forms their identity" (Corte Constitucional de Colombia, 2009). Identity, and precisely the rupture thereof, constitutes the main source of inspiration. When that connection with the place where you were born, grew up, and were formed is broken in a traumatic manner, memories are transformed, cultural practices are transformed, community networks are broken, and, above all, the way of expressing oneself is transformed. Questions arise such as: in what way can a soundtrack be created that reflects that rupture of identity? During the nineteen-eighties, the strengthening of guerrilla groups and their control over drug trafficking routes prompted the appearance of paramilitary groups in the face of the State's inability to guarantee security in the regions—actors who subsequently received backing from sectors of the public forces—; nevertheless, this triggered violent disputes for territorial control, forcing many families to abandon their homes in order to survive. "Displacement was the last resource of survival resorted to by the population," faced with the fear of forced recruitment, reprisals for alleged links with the different actors of the conflict, or becoming victims of extrajudicial executions ("false positives"), perpetrated by agents of the public forces, who falsely presented civilians as combatants killed in combat. Taking into account the complexity of this conflict, which still persists, we decided to select the book *Desterrados: crónicas del desarraigo*, by Alfredo Molano, who provides us with deeply human accounts of the conflict, moving away from figures and political abstraction. This book provides us with an ideal narrative for musical creation, by presenting stories that unfold in specific territories with their own musical culture: Chocó, Urabá, the Plains of Ariari, Putumayo, and Magdalena Medio, showing that the conflict and uprootedness were not experienced in a single way. Each territory proposes a different relationship with memory, community, and landscape. These differences became the starting point to develop a diverse sonic palette, capable of approaching different experiences of the country without reducing Colombian identity to a single musical language, but rather through its integration and confluence. For just as Colombia was transformed into a confluence of people in constant transit, this phenomenon was also translated into music, especially in the timbral aspect.

2.2.2 How to Interpret the Conflict Musically?

This phase was one of the most complicated, since after reading the book, the question we asked ourselves was: how can we create specific music for each story? Then, if each story has

a specific region, why not make the music of that region when the story is told? However, we faced two conflicts: the first was narrative, as all the chronicles possessed a similar structure: "I am at home, the conflict arrives, I must escape, I arrive at another place, and I have to adapt." This sequence led us to create eight cues with the same structure, lacking depth and superficially appropriating specific accounts to compose music that, in our judgment, lacked narrative and expressive value. The second conflict was based on reducing each story to the rhythmic characteristics of the region, to a specific sound, to a timbre, and to a place that as musicians we did not even know with the depth necessary to create a work respectful of tradition, falling into simple regionalism. This procedure ended up reducing experiences to rhythms, instruments, and regional conventions that did not necessarily express the particular experience of their protagonists. It was concluded that what makes each story special should not automatically come from where it occurs, but from how each protagonist experiences uprootedness. Finally, we arrived at the question that established a concrete starting point for the project: what is the transversal axis?, what is that which connects all the stories? And the answer is not a region, a musical genre, nor a specific Colombian instrumentation: it is uprootedness understood as the rupture of the bond between an individual, their memory, their territory, and their identity. We understood that the music had to offer cohesion because all the protagonists face a similar dilemma: what remains of a person when they must leave the place to which they belonged? From this premise, different moments were conceived in which the music would not represent a particular individual, nor a region, nor an isolated anecdote. The soundtrack would constitute the attempt to portray the feeling of being displaced, dispossessed, and uprooted. Questions arose such as: what does a home, connection, community, tranquility in Colombia sound like?, what does danger sound like?, fear, death, and letting go?, what does looking from afar at what was once loved sound like?, what does remembering, or burying sound like?, and, finally, what does resilience sound like? Therefore, a cue sheet was designed that contained all those moments that an uprooted person must face. From a subjective and artistic perspective, we transformed into music the feeling with which each character expresses their version of their exile in each of the chronicles.

This ended up looking in the following manner:

CUE	Concept	Musical Question	Description
M0 Prologue	The Exile Remembers	How can the sound of one's homeland evoke a traumatic memory while allowing resilience, not sorrow, to become the dominant emotional force?	A musical reflection on exile, memory, and the enduring connection to one's homeland. The cue transforms nostalgia and grief into resilience.
M1. Territory	Belonging	How does a place sound before being lost? How does "home" sound?	Create the theme of territory, a theme about home?
M2. Presence	Arrival of conflict	How does something foreign enter within that landscape?	Something dark, heartless, violent, that represents this uprooting force
M3. Threat	Fear and control	How does the perception of the same territory change?	Very intimate, what do I feel now in what is supposed to be my home
M4. Uprootedness	Expulsion	What happens when music loses its center?	Nostalgia, leaving something behind, farewell
M5. Transit	Displacement	What elements survive while everything changes?	Movement, uncertainty, surviving
M6. Non-place	City / exile	How does an identity out of context sound?	Alien, wild, uprooted, unknown, industrial
M7. Memory	Recollection	Can the territory be reconstructed musically?	Melancholy, memories, longings for home

M8. Impossible return	Transformed identity	Can one return to the same place after trauma?	Restoration, reconstruction, returning home, creating a new home, who am I? who are we? A music of resilience

With the intention of giving a voice to the protagonist of each chronicle, a compilation of phrases from the book that had a connection with the way in which we decided to musically narrate this story was made. From these quotes, we used artificial intelligence to create a script that would unite the voice of each person into a single narration in a poetic and linear manner, and thus facilitate the compositional process.

The script and the sequence of events are as follows:

The Land That Remains Within

Poetic script for eight cues.

The Displaced One is a fictional collective voice. It does not speak on behalf of the protagonists; rather, it connects their testimonies. The quotations from the book must retain their own distinct voice, separate from that of the narrator.

M0 - Prologue

BLACK.

A breath is heard. Then, the sound of hands at work.

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

I did not know I had a home until they began to take it away from me.

Before that, the land had no name. It was simply the place where I woke up, where I knew how to find water, and where someone recognised my footsteps before seeing me arrive.

Back then, I was not yet displaced.

I was someone who belonged.

M1 — Territory

IMAGE

Osiris's hands are at work. They grind, cook, sow, and put things in order. The camera does not show a grand landscape; it stays close to the body, the objects, and everyday movements.

OSIRIS (V.O.)

> "My father was a farmer who knew the land. It was his life."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

The home began in the hands.

Within them lay food, work, and the way of caring for others. Every object had its familiar place. Every sound seemed to know where it came from and where it was meant to return.

The camera finds Ángela's bare feet. She runs along the street, plays with her siblings, and approaches the river.

ÁNGELA (V.O.)

> "In Nechí, I never wore shoes. I walked barefoot, just like my siblings, my cousins, and almost everyone in the village."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

I belonged without knowing it.

The land recognised me by the way I walked upon it.

TRANSITION

Ángela's footsteps continue, but another pulse begins to mingle with them: the distant engine of a motorcycle.

The music presents its complete material: the centre, the motif, and a pedal tone that coexists with a sense of stability.

M2 — Presence

IMAGE

Ángela remains near the river. The place seems unchanged, but the adults lower their voices. A motorcycle passes through the children's play. No one explains what is happening.

ÁNGELA (V.O.)

> "I never saw any dead people in the river, but we did hear people saying that the river was bringing out dead bodies."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

Violence did not come in by breaking down the door.

First, it changed the meaning of things.

The river ceased to be just a river. A motorcycle ceased to be just a motorcycle. My father's silence began to say things I could not yet understand.

The water carries the image towards Cajambre. We see María José, Aníbal, and the community living beside the mangrove forest.

LA DERROTA (V.O.)

> "One might have said they were living through a peaceful and well-deserved twilight."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

We believed we had travelled far enough.

As we watched the evening fall, someone else had already begun watching us.

TRANSITION

An unfamiliar boat appears in the distance. It does not approach yet. It remains motionless, like a presence watching from afar.

The music preserves the world of M1 but introduces a foreign element that does not belong to its harmony, timbre, or pulse.

M3 — Threat

IMAGE

The space becomes narrow. Animals are found dead. Armed men ask questions, keep watch, and wait. After Aníbal's murder, the camera remains with María José.

We do not show the gunshot. We show the void.

LA DERROTA (V.O.)

> "No one wanted to lend their house for the wake, and they could not find a single coffin in the village."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

The first home we lost was not the one we were forced to leave.

It was the home that stopped welcoming us.

Aníbal's body remains without a place. A voice sings an *alabado*, a traditional devotional song. When it ends, the sound does not resolve; it remains suspended.

That silence takes us to Pinillos.

LOS SILENCIOS (V.O.)

> "Long silences that were more frightening than the bombs."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

We learned to listen to what made no sound.

A pause could mean waiting. A breath could give us away. Fear turned the entire community into a single body trying not to move.

TRANSITION

Amid the silence, a door is heard closing. Then another. Someone begins packing their belongings.

The music must behave like a latent threat: it may shift from contained tension to a state of alert without becoming an action spectacle.

M4 — Uprooting

IMAGE

The community gathers what is essential. No one knows how long they will be away. Some close their doors; others leave them open.

LOS SILENCIOS (V.O.)

> "People fled into the wilderness with what little strength they had left."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

One begins to leave before moving their feet.

One leaves when looking at their home and calculating what they can carry. When they understand that a photograph weighs less than a table, yet can contain an entire life.

In another territory, Nubia abandons the farm and the shop. The image connects hands letting go of a door with other hands releasing a fence.

NUBIA (V.O.)

> "We left the farm and the shop behind, abandoned. The house and everything else."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

We left without knowing which part of ourselves should remain behind to look after what we had abandoned.

We walked forward.

But something continued waiting behind the door.

TRANSITION

The last sound of home is cut off. All that remains are footsteps, a wheel rolling along the road, and the flow of water.

The music represents the rupture of identity: leaving without looking back, leaving loved ones behind without knowing whether they survived.

M5 — Transit

IMAGE

Nubia travels along roads, through bedsheets and cities. Each new place seems like the beginning of something, but the movement never stops.

NUBIA (V.O.)

"We settled in as best we could and began thinking about a new life again."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

Starting over became a habit.

We learned to build quickly, to never fully unpack our suitcases, and to recognise the moment when it was necessary to leave once again.

Moving did not mean arriving.

Surviving did not mean finding a destination.

The sound of the road transforms into water. Toñito is left alone facing the sea.

EL BARCO TURCO (V.O.)

"I felt like spreading my arms like birds and crying like a newborn."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

When he could no longer move forward, he floated.

He did not fight the current. He allowed his body to remember what it had learned before words.

For a moment, survival consisted solely of remaining afloat.

TRANSITION

The sea slowly disappears beneath the noise of the city. Toñito's outstretched arms become the streets of Cartagena.

The music retains some recognisable fragments while everything else changes. The layers represent the body, memory, and the environment in motion.

M6 — Non-place

IMAGE

Toñito arrives in the Mandela neighbourhood. He is surrounded by people, makeshift houses, and movement, yet he cannot find anywhere to stay.

EL BARCO TURCO (V.O.)

> "It is not like it was back there; here, everyone is on their own."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

In my homeland, anyone who arrived was offered food and a place to sleep.

Here, there were thousands of doors, but none was meant for me.

The city knew how many of us there were. It knew where to prevent us from entering, where to drive us out, and which documents to ask us for. The only thing it did not know was our name.

The camera moves from Cartagena to the bus terminal in Ibagué. Ninfa prepares arepas while other travellers depart and return around her.

EL JARDÍN (V.O.)

> "Now we make a living selling arepas at the Ibagué bus terminal, until they let us stay, because every day the authorities are cracking down on us more and more."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

Ninfa lived in a place built for departure.

She watched others come and go while she remained trapped between hunger, her children, and the life that had been buried somewhere else.

TRANSITION

The steam rising from an arepa covers the image. When it clears, we are no longer at the terminal: we are standing before Ninfa's lost garden.

The music must feel out of context: the motif retains its identity, but it is surrounded by a space that does not recognise it or allow it to rest.

M7 — Memory

IMAGE

The garden appears incomplete. We do not know whether we are seeing it as it once was or as Ninfa manages to remember it.

The white dress, Álvaro's face, the farm, and the bus terminal overlap.

EL BARCO TURCO (V.O.)

> "Without a burial, the dead remain alive."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

When we could not say goodbye, the dead continued walking alongside us.

They did not return as ghosts. They returned through the spaces they had left behind: a chair, a voice, a side of the bed that no one ever occupied again.

EL JARDÍN (V.O.)

> "Everything was buried there. I left everything behind, everything. I only took the children with me."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

We believed that memory would allow us to return.

But memory does not reconstruct the entire territory. It preserves fragments, alters distances, fills some gaps, and invents others.

The image moves away from Ninfa and finds Molano writing. On the table lie testimonies, names, and places. He does not speak yet. He listens.

TRANSITION

The sound of the pencil moving across the paper repeats the rhythm of Osiris's hands in M1.

The music recovers earlier materials as imperfect memories: incomplete, out of sync, or altered by everything that has been lived through.

M8 — Impossible Return

IMAGE

Molano is in Barcelona, but he hears sounds from Colombia. The present city and the remembered country coexist within the same space.

DESDE EL EXILIO (V.O.)

> "I lived forty-eight hours a day: twenty-four in my country and twenty-four here."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

I lived in two places and was not entirely in either of them.

One body walked through the streets of exile. The other continued travelling along roads, listening to voices, and searching for a door through which to return.

DESDE EL EXILIO (V.O.)

> "I did not wish to put down roots far from my homeland, even if I do not feel like a foreigner here."

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

For years, I believed that returning meant retracing the same road in the opposite direction.

Then I understood that the place I remembered had changed. The person who wished to return had changed, too.

The image returns to Osiris. He walks through his home, touches the walls, and looks at himself in the mirror. His hands begin working again.

He does not rebuild the house that existed before.

He builds a place for the person he has become.

THE DISPLACED ONE (V.O.)

I am not only what I lost.

I am the land I was able to carry with me.

The voices that refused to disappear.

The hands that began again.

Perhaps returning does not mean going back to the same place.

Perhaps it means recognising what still remains and building from there.

FINAL IMAGE

Osiris's hands repeat the movement from the opening scene. The gesture is recognisable, but its meaning has changed.

BLACK.

The music recovers the complete motif of displacement, but transformed. It must retain a perceptible scar: this is not a restoration of the past, but a new possibility of belonging.

Quotations taken from *Desterrados: crónicas del desarraigo*.

2.3 Research on Colombian Musical Practices and Behaviours

When we delve into the gigantic world of Colombian music, it is impossible to recognise that there is a rhythm capable of representing the country's sonic identity. Colombia's great diversity is also manifested in its musical practices and the number of variations from one region to another and even within the same region. The Ministry of Culture organises traditional Colombian music into eleven regional axes, including the music of the Northern and Southern Pacific, Andean, Llanos, Caribbean and Amazonian music. However, the same institution clarifies that this classification "does not seek to be exclusive or exhaustive", but rather functions as a tool for studying the relationships between territory, instrumental formats and musical practices (Ministerio de Cultura, 2009).

We immediately understand the very strong relationship that music and territory have in Colombia. During the analysis, we began to find similarities that did not necessarily depend on an instrument or a genre. One of them was the way of organising time through cycles, and another was the collective construction of rhythm between several layers.

For this project, rhythms will not be used as decorative elements intended to quickly indicate that a scene takes place in Colombia. Nor is the intention to copy traditional patterns and place them in the orchestra. The objective will be to identify some of their internal principles, such as subdivision, accentuation, repetition, alternation, the relationship between instruments and the sensation of movement, in order to subsequently fragment them, then sample them and finally transform them electronically. For this reason, we do not copy the

complete rhythms. We take elements such as their accents, subdivisions or forms of repetition and transform them until they work dramatically within the scene.

The main elements will be:

- **Repetition, cycle and rupture:**

In the creation of most of the cues, the word **cycle** was what dictated the structure. In Colombian music, patterns are constantly repeated but rarely in the same way; there is always a variation, an extra element or an element outside.

When we relate these patterns to the book *Desterrados*, uprooting can be understood as the rupture of a cycle. We have a daily organisation of time, before the conflict, celebrations, gatherings, events, community and patterns that represent home. Violence interrupts this everyday life and tranquillity and forces people to organise their lives under new conditions.

We chose to create strings in which the harmonic foundation was as simple as possible (for example, 4 chords), repeat the chords in a loop and begin building from there. We can see this in cues such as M51.5, M5, M8, where the harmonic foundation is simple and sound layers are built upon it, gradually growing in cycles.

- **Collective construction and relationship between layers**

An important characteristic of many Colombian practices is that rhythm does not belong to a single instrument. It is constructed through the interaction of several layers.

In *pitos y tambores* practices, for example, the Ministry of Culture identifies relationships between solo voice, chorus, handclaps and different percussion instruments. In *bailes cantados*, the alternation between a main voice and the group's response is an essential part of the musical structure (Valencia, 2004).

This interaction interests us because it allows us to understand identity as a collective construction. In relation to the story, a pattern distributed among several instruments and a wall of sound built little by little can progressively lose its components until it is reduced to a single voice. When a layer disappeared, we did not simply want to thin out the texture. We wanted it to feel as though something from that community had disappeared, that something had been fractured. We can observe this collective construction in cues such as M5 (Transit)

and M8 (Within My Roots), cues that are formed through layers and that are finally reduced until they remain as individual structures, “loneliness”.

- **Metric Flexibility and Displacement of Accents**

The study of the accents of the Bambuco, Currulao, Bullerengue, Cumbia, among others, was taken into account to a great extent in the creation of this suite.

In some practices, binary and ternary subdivisions coexist; in others, accents can produce a metric perception different from that indicated by the written time signature. There are also anticipations, offbeats and superimpositions that make the rhythm feel in constant movement. We focused on studying the sensation of instability and movement that occurs when accents can be heard in more than one way. This generated ambiguity became a narrative tool.

The most widely used rhythm was the Bambuco, where we highlighted 2 against 3 and vice versa to represent displacement, one of the main themes (the theme of uprooting); for the most part, it appears in a 2-against-3 structure.

In cues such as *Threat*, for example, the material retains the same subdivision while its accents change position. The musical territory would remain recognisable, but it would begin to feel unstable. In M5, despite the fact that the Cumbia is the driving force of the work, we hear displaced accents symbolising the character's displacement.

- **Timbre and Materiality**

When deciding not to fall into regionalisms, we mixed timbres according to our taste; we literally developed Colombian music. Tiples with gaitas, quenas with drums, marimbas with bandolas, and so on.

However, we also do not assume that the presence of a traditional instrument is sufficient to produce sonic identity. Using a tiple or a marimba within the orchestra does not automatically make a work express a Colombian experience.

Identity will depend on the relationship between the instrument, its behaviour, the context investigated and the narrative function it fulfils within the composition. In this case, the main premise was: the choice of instruments has to fulfil the narrative function beyond their traditional use. This led us to creations in which the marimba ended up sounding like home,

the choir like memory, the gaitas like tears, the orchestra like the unfamiliar, the drums like violence, the quenas like the wind, and the tiple like movement.

- **Hybridisation and Transformation**

We are convinced that the best way to apply Colombian music to a cinematic context is by resorting to hybridisation and transformation. Colombian music has never remained isolated; it has changed through migrations, exchanges, urbanisation processes, technologies and encounters between traditions.

We are interested in exploring how these elements can adapt to other languages without losing the memory of where they come from. Our purpose is not to imitate or reconstruct Colombian musical traditions, but to transform them and make them visible within a different audiovisual language.

In this way, the orchestra and electronic processes were not elements added at the end of the process to make the music sound more cinematic. From the beginning, they were part of the experimentation and were mixed with the instruments, rhythms and musical behaviours studied. This combination allowed us to find new colours and ways of using these materials and, above all, to place them at the service of the central idea of the work: representing uprooting in “Desterrados”, or gender-based violence in “Pedacito de Tela”.

2.4 Experiences

2.4.1 BAM (Bogotá Audiovisual Market)

During the first months of the research, one of the main purposes of the project was to attend one of the most important events in Colombia, the *BAM (Bogotá Audiovisual Market)*. BAM is the most important audiovisual market in Colombia and one of the strongest points of reference in the region. The key difference is that it is not a film festival designed for the public merely to attend screenings of productions, but a business marketplace where the real industry operates.

Directors, producers, composers, post-production houses, distributors and representatives of platforms or channels attend and sit face to face there. It is the space where people pitch scripts, seek national and international co-production partnerships, close distribution deals and obtain the financing needed to be able to shoot. At the end of the day, it is the meeting

point par excellence for building relationships, finding out how industry standards and calls for applications are evolving, and ensuring that an idea or a film in development makes the leap from paper to screen with people who truly make decisions in the industry. In this sense, BAM was attended with the aim of generating contacts, finding out what the local industry is doing, understanding the perspective of local composers in relation to it and, finally, obtaining audiovisual projects.

The experience of this event is included as part of the research for 3 reasons: Firstly, through it, the contract for the production of the short film “Pedacito de Tela” was signed. Secondly, we recorded many of our fellow composers' opinions regarding our research question. Finally, it was an opportunity to apply what had been learned in the “Career Development” module with Penka Kouneva, where we discussed partnerships, sent pitches, created valuable contacts and closed future business deals.

The first step in our participation in BAM was the mass sending of emails to different production companies and directors with the intention of collaborating with them by offering them high-quality music and the recording of session 15 of our Master's degree.

We received responses from many of them and arranged in-person meetings during the event where feasibility and delivery times were discussed.

Contracts were secured for projects such as: production of the short film “Pedacito de Tela” (Colombia), short film “The Little Doll” (USA), feature film “Doble Vida” (Colombia), and a panel and a film concert for the animation festival ANIBIA. These opportunities are highly relevant not only to the project but also demonstrate the application of the knowledge acquired throughout the Master's studies.

Each of the projects had a different outlook. *Pedacito de Tela* was filmed on the Colombian coast and represents the fight against violence towards women; *The Little Doll* is a Christmas fantasy short film.

Due to delivery timelines, the only project that coincides with the timelines of the major project was *Pedacito de Tela*, which also contributes enormously to our research, as it is a short film in which the dynamics of local music and instruments can be used in an audiovisual and cinematic context.

2.4.2 First Ibero-American Congress of Film Music Composers (Radiography of the Current Musical Scene in Colombia)

El Compositorio is a personal project, led by the writers of this thesis, which began as a collective and community of Colombian composers for film and video games and is now an established company offering musical services for audiovisual projects. It has a permanent team and workflows that we will present later, since it was key to organising the artefact's delivery timelines.

This company was one of the main partners of the First Ibero-American Congress of Film Music Composers, as it offered a live opening concert, an exhibition on the history of film music in Colombia, assistants for recording processes, monitors for masterclasses and participation in the third character laboratory.

2.5.2.1 Animated Short Film Concert

Being the welcome concert for an event of such high calibre involves a great deal of creativity and the need to connect with both local and international attendees. For this reason, as leaders of El Compositorio, we proposed a concert in which we would present original animated shorts with film music featuring Colombian timbres.

Therefore, a group of musicians was hired and organised as follows: 3 bowed strings, Guitar, Tiple, Marimba de Chonta, Colombian Gaita, Clarinet, Tambora and 2 voices.

The selection of these instruments marked a precedent in the musical development of our thesis. This was because we mixed instruments from different regions of Colombia, instruments that are not accustomed to interacting, that do not share tunings, that do not share a cultural tradition or a way of playing different rhythms.

Taking these timbral and rhythmic “inconsistencies” into account, it was fascinating to see how a Caribbean gaita performed a Chocó Bambuco, or how a Marimba de Chonta native to the Pacific freely performed a Caribbean Cumbia, or how a tiple blended rhythmically and melodically among all the works, giving a touch of brightness and presence that is usually only seen in Andean music. On the other hand, the bowed strings provided a harmonic foundation, familiarity with the cinematic language and an international touch to this proposal.

This marked a before and after in the project, since it involved an in-depth learning process regarding the possibilities and limitations of each instrument. We learned about the need to have several gaitas tuned to different keys for each work, and their dynamic limitation, since it is very difficult to play them softly. We observed how most performers of these traditional instruments, especially marimba players and gaita players, do not read traditional notation, which initially made synchronisation difficult. In addition, we dealt with issues of temperament and dynamic balance. However, through rehearsals, a very distinctive and original sound was established, the scores were corrected according to the musicians' indications regarding performance and tuning, and finally, the concert took place and was very well received. It was innovative and generated interest among foreign attendees because of the timbral mixture that had never been heard before.

Regarding the short films, completely original short films made in Colombia were selected, but their stories did not necessarily have to be related to Colombian stories. These were the projects:

- Hasta que suene el timbre
- Ficus
- Mohan
- Dia Cinco
- Warring Triad (Video Game Trailer)



It is important to clarify that this was a collaborative project in which other composers also took part, and the premise given to them was: Use Colombian elements to narrate any of the assigned stories, do not fall into stereotypes, explore timbres and rhythms, and mix them in the most organic way possible.

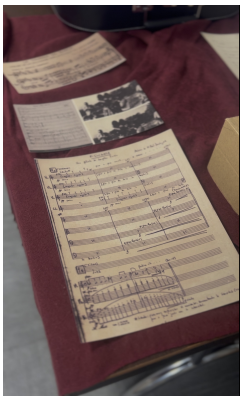
Finally, we approached the ensemble with the conducting skills learned at the Film Scoring Academy of Europe

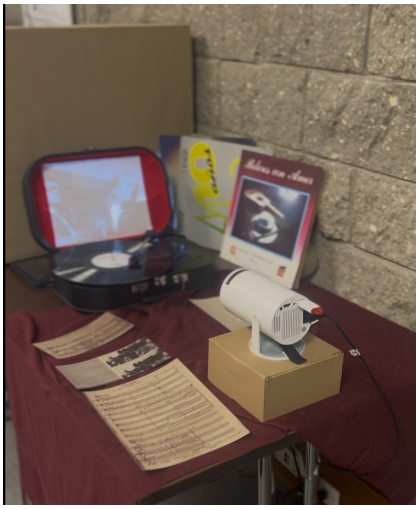
2.4.2.2 Exhibition

Little is known about the history of film music in Colombia, and one of the few existing studies on this subject is *"A Brief History of Cinematic Music in Colombia" by Erica Acuna (2025).* This writing was the gem that inspired this project, because learning how composers throughout our history have explored narrative and what music they have created made us wonder whether there were patterns or an identity behind all these film scores.

In the chapter on films and their music, we will explore the answer to this question in greater depth. However, as *Compositorio*, we created a small exhibition about this writing that traces the history of cinematic music in Colombia, from silent cinema to the present day, highlighting composers, aesthetic changes, technical advances, economic difficulties and the progressive professional consolidation of the profession. We divided it into five stations:

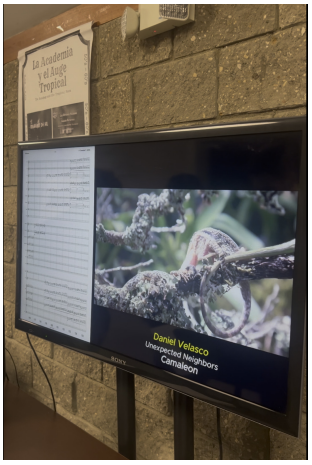
- **The First Steps of Film Music in Colombia:** Live accompaniment, popular music and the first original scores, such as the *Waltz from La tragedia del silencio* and later works such as *Pisingaña*. In this space, a gramophone was placed, on whose lid films such as *Flores del Valle*, *El río de las tumbas* and *La tragedia del silencio* were projected. They were accompanied by vinyl records that simulated how film music was synchronised in Colombia in the past, that is, with traditional Colombian songs.





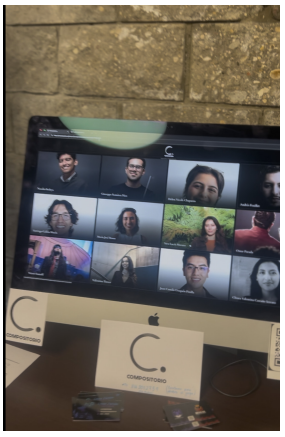
- **Music Begins to Experiment and Narrate in New Ways:** Electronic music, academic music, new synchronisation techniques and sonic explorations in works such as *Camilo, el cura guerrillero*, *Pura sangre* and *La estrategia del caracol*. At this station, an immersive box was created where people could enter and enjoy a little of the history of how the music for the best avant-garde films in our history was created and synchronised.

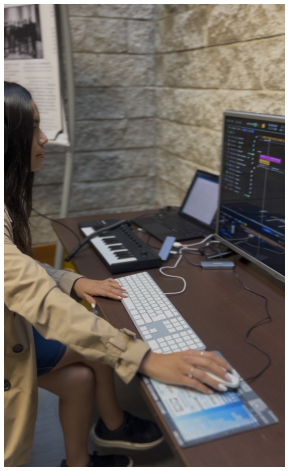




- **From Isolated Efforts to a Professional Scene:** New generations of composers, greater specialisation and organisations such as Mucine consolidate film music as a growing profession. In this space, excerpts from recordings by members of MUCINE (Film Music Association in Colombia) were projected, and many of these composers' scores were physically exhibited.

- **Compositorio Station:** The portfolio of composers associated with Compositorio was presented on an interactive website where, through a survey, other composers and industry professionals could connect with the composer who most closely matched their tastes, goals and workflows.
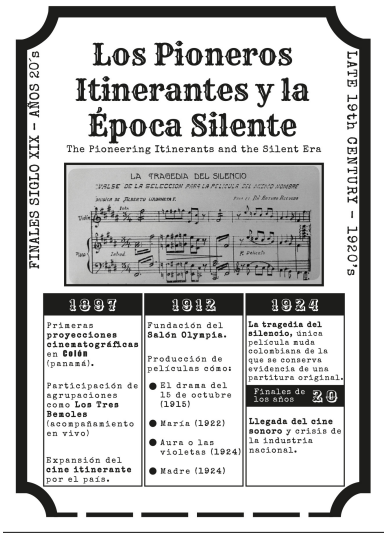




- **Collective Creation Space:** There is nothing more valuable for a Colombian composer than being surrounded by the brilliant minds of the moment, by the composers who drive the local industry. Because of this, we created a collective creation space so that we could create a joint work as a community. A Logic session was loaded with an arsenal of virtual instruments at hand for

people to create as they wished. In the end, the results were very experimental, but it was very enriching to observe how each person approached those minutes of composition and how they managed their time, how they composed in real time and how they adapted to their colleagues' proposals.

On the other hand, the following posters were created, forming a timeline that guided the exhibition, based on Erica Acuna's text.













2.4.2.3 Masterclasses

There was a variety of masterclass panels in which several local and international speakers participated.

The international reference was Andy Hill, a key figure in music supervision and film education in Los Angeles; the Polish composers Mikołaj Stroiński, widely recognised for the music of The Witcher 3, and Wojciech Urbański, focused on a very contemporary mixture of orchestra and electronics; as well as Micaela Carballo (Argentina), with experience in conducting and projects for platforms such as Disney+, and the Mexican Karina Rivero, with ongoing work in composition and orchestration.

On the Colombian and regional side, figures with considerable professional experience in music came together: Óscar Olaya Maldonado, with a key career in composition and orchestration for film and video games; Felipe Téllez, who combines traditional symphonic training with his experience in Canada; Camilo Sanabria, with a strongly defined authorial language in independent cinema; and Manuel Gordillo, who, through his work on La Tina, contributes that comprehensive vision in which music and sound design complement each other. Taken together, this is a group that reflects the reality of the profession today: orchestral mastery, hybrid production and a technical standard designed to engage with the global industry and, above all, Colombian instruments and rhythms.

The most relevant example may be Camilo Sanabria, composer of the original music for the Netflix original series based on Gabriel García Márquez's book *One Hundred Years of Solitude*. This masterclass is key, and for this purpose, we need to understand the context of One Hundred Years of Solitude and how it represents Colombia.

One Hundred Years of Solitude feels so close to us because, at its core, it speaks about what we have had to experience in Colombia. García Márquez does not invent Macondo simply to create a fantasy story; he uses it to show what happened in the country during the nineteenth century and much of the twentieth century, when towns grew on their own, far away from everything, and political violence did not allow people to live in peace.

The novel touches very real aspects of our society for three specific reasons:

War: Through Colonel Aureliano Buendía and his more than thirty lost wars, the story shows how violence becomes a habit. At first, people fight for a cause, but over the years they continue fighting simply because they no longer know how to live any other way. It is the same thing we have seen happen here for generations: the names of the conflict change, but the dead and the pain within families remain the same.

Pain: The moment of the strike at the railway station, where the workers are shot at and the next day nobody saw anything and the government says there were no deaths, summarises a very deep wound in Colombia. There has always been this distance between what people truly suffer in the countryside or in the regions and what is subsequently said in the news or in official documents, as if the suffering of others did not count.

Loneliness: Each of the Buendías lives enclosed within their own pride or memories, without listening to others and making the same mistakes as their parents or grandparents. Macondo reflects this difficulty, so characteristic of us, of pulling together in the same direction. Everyone survives as best they can on their own piece of land, and this lack of unity causes history to repeat itself over and over again.

In the end, the book not only shows the losses and blows we have suffered as a society. It also reveals the stubbornness to keep going, the courage of families to sustain themselves amid disaster and the need to tell what happened so that we do not lose sight of where we come from.

The music for One Hundred Years of Solitude was not an easy task, much less for a platform that broadcasts content internationally such as Netflix. The way it was created follows two strands: the song, using themes by Juancho Valencia of Colombian music, and the incidental music, employing a certain hybridisation and modernisation of cues such as the one for Mariposa, where the symphony orchestra is used with a solo Gaita, but it is processed using modern audio-processing techniques. Although the music still sounds quite Colombian, it also takes an important step towards the "acoustic hybridisation mentioned in the introduction".

We also had the opportunity to see the career paths of composers such as Karina Rivero (Mexico) and Micaela Carballo (Argentina). The latter is based in Los Angeles and has also had the opportunity to bring South American culture into international contexts, like her compatriot Gustavo Santaolalla.

Likewise, the Polish composers also showed great interest in the local sound. Wojciech Urbański was one of those who showed the most interest, dedicating a large part of his time to recording in the studio alongside local instruments and singers.

2.4.2.4 Recordings and Experimentation

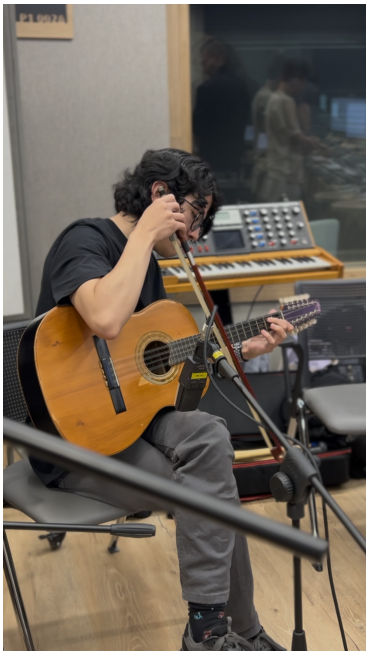
Wojciech "Wojtek" Urbański is primarily characterised by his versatility in combining orchestral and cinematic music with contemporary electronic sounds. His work is not limited to a single genre, but moves between instrumental compositions and electronic productions intended for other contexts, such as dance music.

His participation in the congress was a great inspiration for our project, as he led an exploration laboratory in one of the studios at Universidad de los Andes. The exercise was mainly focused on the timbral and rhythmic exploration of different Colombian instruments. For this purpose, the studio had a wide variety of percussion instruments, gaitas, bandola, tiple and marimba de chonta, among others. Several performers improvised over rhythmic foundations created by themselves or by Urbański, who recorded, mixed and transformed the results to construct different tracks.

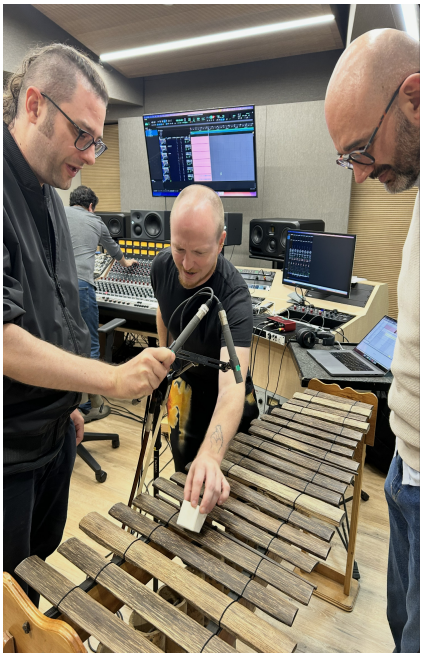
The most interesting aspect of this space was not only bringing together Colombian instruments and performers, but also exploring what other sounds these instruments could produce when taken outside their usual uses, how they could be mixed with one another and

to what extent they could be decontextualised from their roots without losing their identity. During these explorations, for example, we saw how a violin bow was passed over the wooden bars of a marimba de chonta or over the strings of a tiple, seeking sounds that we would not normally associate with these instruments. Experiments were also conducted with female voices originating from bullerengue singing, taking some of their characteristic gestures as a starting point to test new sonic possibilities.









2.4.2.5 The Third Character

The Third Character was an activity carried out by Zoé Martinez to bring composers together with directors and allow them to pitch for an audiovisual work at any stage of its development, from the idea to post-production. When we speak of music as a "third character", we mean ceasing to treat the score as a simple decorative background or a tool for emphasising what is already seen on screen. Instead of limiting itself to accompanying the image, the music enters the frame as another actor, with a clear intention, a point of view and the ability to intervene actively in the scene.

In this way, the idea of the third character is used at various congresses, summits and festivals in Europe to bring composers together with directors and producers. We had the opportunity to participate actively in the Third Character, and the briefs we received were also closely related to the sound we had been developing and researching throughout the creation of our degree project.

Among the projects we received was *Un Castillo*, which tells the story of how children suffer from armed conflict. The aim was to create the music almost diegetically, almost as if the children themselves were creating it and also constructing their own world. What was interesting was that the setting was closely related to the mountains, which was why the director and producer also wanted the music to be Colombian and Andean, allowing us to delve deeper into the research we had been conducting. This production was in a development phase prior to pre-production, so the pitch came directly from the synopsis, the script and the general idea of the short film. A children's composition was presented to the director, using the sound of Colombian gaitas mixed with sonic atmospheres. They liked the proposal quite a lot, which, although short and precise, already combined a Colombian sound with the modern processing of hybrid tools characteristic of today's film music composition scene.

Another proposal received was a project called *Las Crías*. This was already in post-production and had even been present at the aforementioned BAM. The producer attended and told us that they were looking for a much more experimental sound. The audiovisual work takes place in the countryside, so the proposal was developed directly through the recording of samples of objects from these areas: the scraping of fences, the wind

at night, the sound of grass. Although it is not strictly an instrumental sound, it is closely related to developing an identity of its own, deeply rooted in the place where it was recorded.

2.6 Colombian Cinema and Its Music

Conrado Xalabarder (2013) argues that a film composer must also be a filmmaker and deeply understand musical resources. In this context, as film composers, we delve into the world of Colombian films, since, in order to propose something innovative, it is necessary to know what has been done in this particular genre and how composers have narrated these stories, as well as what is happening in the current scene, that is, what contemporary composers are doing. The following is a short list of Colombian productions that are musically, historically, or narratively related to our thesis:

Film / Musical authorship	Documented musical characteristics	How it explores themes related to the research	Related cues
La estrategia del caracol (1993). Director: Sergio Cabrera. Music: Germán Arrieta and Gonzalo Sagarminaga.	The soundtrack combines orchestra, choir, tiples and guitars. Ricardo Jaramillo conducts the orchestra and the Cartella Choir, while Carlos Posada Durán performs the tiple and guitar parts. It brings together symphonic resources and instruments associated with Colombian musical traditions (Proimágenes Colombia, 1993). The distorted tiple was also an important reference in our	Although the film does not address displacement caused by armed conflict, it explores urban eviction and community resistance. What happens when someone is forced to leave the place where they belong? The threatened loss of a home also puts memories, relationships and shared ways of life at risk.	M1, M4, M6, M8

	creative process for M5 and M6.		
Rodrigo D. No futuro (1990). Director: Víctor Gaviria. Collective repertoire by bands including Mutantex and Pestes; the soundtrack cannot be attributed to a single composer.	Local punk and metal contribute to the characters' identity through distorted guitars, drums and confrontational vocals. Music is not merely external accompaniment: Rodrigo's musical aspirations are central to the story. The relationship between musical practice, sonic identity and narrative is a recurring concern in research on Gaviria's cinema (Lenguaje y Ciencia, 1990).	Music becomes a means of expression and belonging in a city shaped by violence and limited opportunities for young people. Different responses to this reality emerge within the same environment. Punk offers a way to construct an identity and find a place within that context. The connection to our project lies in another form of uprootedness: feeling alienated or out of place within one's own city.	M3, M6
La vendedora de rosas (1998). Director: Víctor Gaviria. Original music: Luis Fernando Franco.	The film features an original incidental score. An analysis of the opening identifies gentle music with religious associations, set against noise and exploding fireworks. This contrast between musical introspection and external commotion is more precise than describing the entire	A city in celebration does not necessarily offer protection or a home. The sonic contrast reveals the distance between collective festivity and Mónica's vulnerability. Her memories of her grandmother connect emotional loss with the search for refuge, suggesting that being	M3, M6, M7

	score as sad music (Trama y Fondo, 1998).	surrounded by people is not the same as belonging.	
El abrazo de la serpiente (2015). Director: Ciro Guerra. Music: Nascuy Linares.	The sparse score uses piano, guitar, cuatro, maracas, percussion, synthesizers and field recordings. Its approach favours texture and experimentation over large-scale epic orchestration. Recorded voices and the Amazonian environment also contribute to its construction (Crack Magazine, 2026).	The film connects territory, colonial destruction and the survival of knowledge. Its musical approach allows the rainforest to be understood as more than the backdrop to an adventure, connecting it with memory and cultural loss. This raises a question central to our research: what remains when a community has been decimated and its knowledge is under threat?	M1, M2, M7, M8
Pájaros de verano (2018). Directors: Cristina Gallego and Ciro Guerra. Music: Leonardo Heiblum.	Research into Wayúu sounds and instruments led to the involvement of the singer who serves as narrator. His participation helped shape the film's organization into cantos. The score is selective rather than continuous and also accompanies the characters' inner lives (The Moveable Fest, 2018).	Music shapes the telling of a communal tragedy rather than merely establishing its setting. The marijuana boom changes kinship ties, obligations and relationships with the territory. Its connection to our project lies in the violent transformation of a world of belonging, although it does not portray	M1, M2, M3, M4, M7

		the same process of displacement described by Molano.	
Monos (2019). Director: Alejandro Landes. Music: Mica Levi.	The score uses bottle whistles, percussion and electronic elements. A rigid, recurring whistle is associated with authority, while another musical idea develops around the bonds between the young characters. The music also draws on electronic dance music's build-up techniques without consistently delivering the anticipated release (Monos press kit, 2019).	The armed group becomes audible through the sounds of discipline, while other materials express the bonds between its young members. The music creates tension between belonging to the group and being subjected to its control. The geography changes, but control and disorientation persist. The score does not seek to identify Colombia through recognizable folk repertoire.	M2, M3, M5
Los colores de la montaña (2010; Colombian release in 2011). Director: Carlos César Arbeláez. Music: Camilo Montilla and Oriol Caro.	The original score combines Colombian tiple with orchestral sounds, sonic textures and cinematic percussion. The sound design establishes the Colombian mountain setting and reinforces the dramatic development of the story (Camilo Montilla, 2010).	The film observes the arrival of armed conflict through children's games and school life. The countryside is not initially presented as a battlefield: an everyday space becomes dangerous without ceasing to be recognizable. This transformation directly	M1, M2, M3, M4

		connects territory, threat and forced departure.	
Siembra (2015). Directors: Ángela Osorio and Santiago Lozano. Documented musical contributions: Jhon Javier Ramos and Diego Balanta; no single composer has been confirmed for the entire soundtrack.	The film contrasts the father's attachment to rural musical traditions with the son's engagement with urban musical mixtures (Mediapart, 2016). Jhon Javier Ramos contributed to Yosner's rhythmic characterization through rap, hip-hop and krump, while Diego Balanta brought knowledge of traditional musical practices to the production (El País, 2016).	This is one of the closest parallels to our research. Displacement produces two different musical relationships with one's origins: preserving them and transforming them. After the son's death, singing and burial turn mourning into a question of territory: where can someone put down roots after already being forced from their home?	M4, M6, M7, M8
Tantas almas (2019). Director: Nicolás Rincón Gille. No non-diegetic score; songs by various authors appear within the narrative.	Amplified reggaeton and vallenato contrast with José's quiet singing. Loudness becomes a means of occupying space and asserting power, while sounds from the natural environment accompany or anticipate danger (Canal Trece, 2019).	A father searches for his sons' bodies: the river is both a route and a site of disappearance. The contrast between overwhelming noise and intimate singing sets domination against memory. Music's power does not depend on genre alone, but on who imposes it and who is forced to become almost inaudible.	M2, M3, M5, M7

Alias María (2015). Director: José Luis Rugeles. Music: Camilo Sanabria.	Camilo Sanabria is credited with the film's music (Festival Internacional de Cine de Morelia, 2015). An academic discussion describes an approach in which the score avoids overpowering the rainforest soundscape and coexists with the persistent presence of insects. Its distinctive feature is the close relationship between music and environmental sound (KU ScholarWorks, 2015).	War is experienced through a pregnant teenager whose body is subject to decisions made by others. The sonic environment places control within everyday life. Its main connection to our project lies in the loss of autonomy and safety rather than nostalgia for a former home.	M2, M3, M5
La sirga (2012). Director: William Vega. No composer identified in the consulted sources. Production sound: César Salazar and Miguel Hernández.	The official credits list the pieces *Mi laguna*, *Mi parcela* and *Sentimiento* without identifying their authors in that entry (Proimágenes Colombia, 2012). The Cinélatino listing does not name a composer. This omission should not be interpreted as evidence that the film contains no music (Cinélatino, 2012).	Alicia attempts to rebuild her life after being displaced, but the threat returns. The connection is particularly clear: physical shelter does not eliminate fear. Her efforts to rebuild a sense of belonging remain vulnerable to renewed violence.	M3, M4, M7, M8

El vuelco del cangrejo (2009). Director: Óscar Ruiz Navia. Composer unconfirmed. Sound: Miguel Vargas, Frédéric Thery and Isabel Torres.	Loudspeaker music participates in the struggle over shared space. Amplification and repetition make it an intrusive presence within the local soundscape, allowing territorial tension to be expressed through sound. This is not simply a matter of distorting natural sounds (Cuaderno Javeriano de Comunicación, 2017).	The newcomer's presence becomes an audible imposition on local life. Territorial conflict is expressed through the question of who decides what the entire community must hear. It is relevant to the arrival of an external force, even when that force is not an armed organization.	M1, M2, M3
La sociedad del semáforo (2010). Director: Rubén Mendoza. Music: Edson Velandia.	Edson Velandia used a wind band whose sounds could resemble street horns and composed short pieces for specific moments on screen. The musical approach deliberately brings instrumental sound close to the surrounding urban noise (Universidad Autónoma de Bucaramanga, 2010).	The characters attempt to control the timing of a traffic light to make a living. Music participates in the surrounding clamour: marginalization is conveyed not only through lament, but also through excess, ingenuity and disorder. The street is simultaneously a workplace, a place of exposure and a precarious community.	M5, M6

Los hongos (2014). Director: Óscar Ruiz Navia. Musical credits: Sebastián Escofet, Zalama Crew and La Llegada del Dios Rata.	The musical credits include Sebastián Escofet, Zalama Crew and La Llegada del Dios Rata (NUMAX, 2014). The inclusion of Zalama Crew connects the soundtrack with the film's interest in youthful expression and the refusal to remain silent (El Universal, 2014).	Rather than portraying the city solely as a place of loss, the film presents creative practices and friendships that make it possible to inhabit it. Its connection to our project lies in the emergence of new forms of belonging, also shaped by family migration, without restoring an untouched place of origin.	M6, M8
Pariente (2016). Director: Iván D. Gaona. Music: Edson Velandia.	The musical approach draws on Spanish ballads from the 1980s, moving close to parody without undermining the drama. This choice reflects the character's sentimental musical tastes rather than a supposed rural folk essence. Velandia's work for the film includes the song *La circunstancia* (Cuadernos de Cine Colombiano, 2016).	The film connects romantic relationships, everyday rural life and violence. Music allows the characters to have desires and tastes that extend beyond the conflict: the threatened territory remains a place where people fall in love and listen to songs. This coexistence is more complex than an absolute separation between peace and war.	M1, M2, M3

Los viajes del viento (2009). Director: Ciro Guerra. Original music: Iván "Tito" Ocampo, with contributions from traditional musicians.	The accordion is more than a timbre: it is a narrative object, a musical practice and the reason for the journey. Musical performances and encounters form part of the characters' actions rather than functioning only as accompaniment (Proimágenes Colombia, 2009).	Ignacio travels to return his instrument after his wife's death. The connection to our thesis lies in mourning, transmission and the movement of musical memory. The film does not depict forced displacement: the journey questions what it means to leave behind a practice that has defined a life.	M1, M5, M7, M8
El río de las tumbas (1965). Director: Julio Luzardo. Incidental music: Trío Los Isleños; repertoire by Lucho Bermúdez and Jorge Villamil.	The credits identify incidental music by Trío Los Isleños and Colombian repertoire including Lucho Bermúdez's *Matambo* and Jorge Villamil's *Espumas*. These credits establish the inclusion of this repertoire, but do not by themselves demonstrate an ironic function in individual scenes (Proimágenes Colombia, 1965).	The river carries bodies past a community marked by indifference. Its thematic connection lies in the coexistence of everyday life and normalized violence. Any interpretation of the music as ironic must be supported by the relationship between the music and the specific scene in which it appears.	M1, M2, M3

Apaporis, secretos de la selva (Colombian release in 2012). Director: Antonio Dorado. Music: Alejandro Ramírez Rojas.	The score is performed by the Filarmónica del Valle and the Universidad del Valle choirs, providing an example of orchestral and choral scoring in an Amazonian documentary (Proimágenes Colombia, 2012). For our research, it offers a reference for exploring how an orchestral ensemble can evoke a Latin American landscape without depending exclusively on traditional instrumental timbres.	The documentary addresses the possible disappearance of languages and ancestral knowledge. Its connection to our research lies more in cultural loss and the memory of place than in displacement caused by armed conflict.	M1, M5
Cantadoras. Memorias de vida y muerte en Colombia (2017). Director: María Fernanda Carrillo Sánchez. A Mexican production about Colombian communities. Music credited to Juan David Castaño, Diego	The voices and experiences of Ceferina Banquéz, Cruz Neyla Murillo, Graciela Salgado, Inés Granja and Bety Ochoa are central. The production's musical credits should be distinguished from the authorship of the individual traditional and personal songs performed in the documentary (Secretaría de Cultura de México, 2019).	Violence is narrated by women who retain their ability to create and pass on knowledge. Tradition appears not only as endangered heritage, but as an active response to historical experience. Singing is something the protagonists do themselves, not a voice added from outside to represent them.	M1, M4, M7, M8

Balanta, Carlos Daniel Balanta, Luis Freiner Hurtado, Vinicio Torres Reyes and Luis Ortega.			
Cantos que inundan el río (2021). Director: Germán Arango Rendón. Original music: Oneida Orejuela Barco; pre-existing music by the Cantadoras de Bojayá.	The musical credits distinguish Oneida Orejuela Barco's original music from pre-existing repertoire performed by the Cantadoras de Bojayá. Singing is central to the account of Oneida's life and her relationship with the community (Habanero Film Sales, 2021).	Its connection lies in the relationship between personal pain, communal memory and the persistence of singing. Music does not merely symbolize grief through emotion: it forms part of the practices through which grief is experienced and communicated. Cultural continuity does not mean that the wound has healed.	M4, M7, M8
Cien años de soledad—Part One (2024). Original music: Camilo Sanabria; on-set music: Juancho Valencia.	The musical world changes alongside Macondo, incorporating gaitas and drums as well as brass and snare drums associated with military presence. Historical research informed decisions about when particular instruments, including the accordion, should appear.	The territory has an audible history: it changes as people, objects, practices and institutions arrive. War enters not only through images of combat, but also through its instruments. The connection to our project lies in the historical transformation of a place	M1, M2, M3, M4, M7

	Instruments are also placed outside their customary musical contexts (Ministerio de las Culturas, las Artes y los Saberes, 2024).	and its family memory, rather than in a fixed sonic identity.	
Distrito salvaje (2018–2019). Original music: Federico Jusid and Adrián Foulkes.	Adrián Foulkes's published soundtrack selection credits the score jointly to Federico Jusid and Foulkes and includes the piece *Objetivo final*. This establishes their shared authorship, without providing sufficient evidence to assign particular instruments or recurring motifs to individual characters (Foulkes and Jusid, 2020).	Jhon Jeiver arrives in Bogotá seeking to reintegrate into civilian life and reconnect with his family, but encounters other networks of violence and corruption. The strongest parallel is the impossibility of leaving the conflict behind simply by moving elsewhere. The city does not offer a safe destination: it demands an understanding of different relationships of power and belonging.	M3, M5, M6, M8
Estimados señores (2024). Director: Patricia Castañeda. Original music: Felipe Téllez.	Felipe Téllez combines electronic textures and orchestration with the timbres of gaita, tiple and bandola, placing these instruments outside their traditional contexts. The	The film focuses not primarily on forced displacement, but on the struggle for women's suffrage. The connection is musical: Colombian identity emerges through	M2, M3, M7

	approach aims to support the emotional narrative without overpowering it (Revista Bombea, 2025).	timbre and its new relationships with the orchestra and electronics, rather than through a specific genre or rhythm.	
El juego de la vida (2026). Director: Andrés Ruiz Zuluaga. Original music created by a Universidad de los Andes team led by Sara Ramírez Márquez.	The original music was developed by a team led by Sara Ramírez Márquez (Ruiz Zuluaga, 2026). In our listening, the score offers a close reference to *Desterrados* through its Caribbean and Andean sonorities and passages that combine traditional rhythms with modern technologies. Its personal musical language accompanies the interviewees' humanity and the frustration of unfulfilled dreams.	Following rural and urban families reveals how inequality can alter a person's relationship with their home. Belonging is connected to memories, family and community, but also to the possibility of remaining somewhere and building a dignified life. These stories allow us to approach uprootedness through a reality different from forced displacement, considering how poverty, lack of opportunity and exclusion can lead people to leave the place they recognize as their own and start again elsewhere.	M5, M6

2.5.2 Artifact
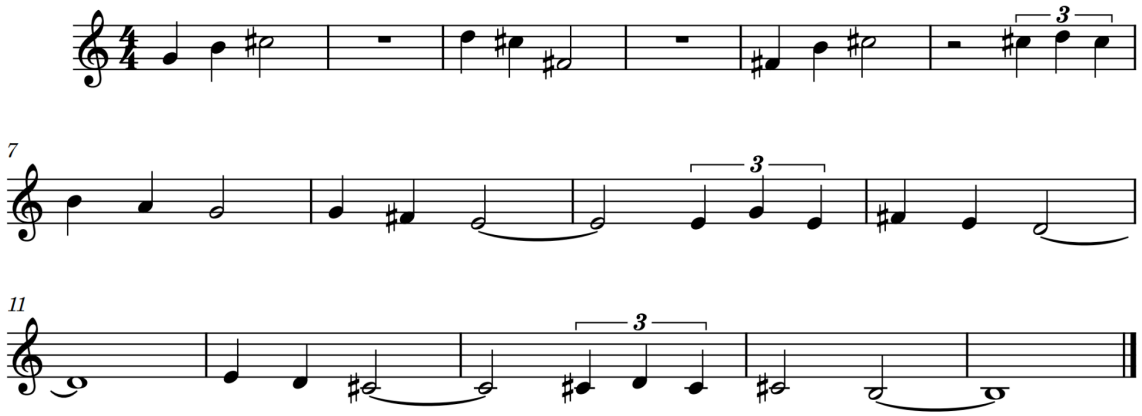
Our artifact comprises the suite composed for the chronicles in the book Desterrados, as well as the composition of the original music for the short film and real industry project Pedacito de tela, which belongs to the series and universe of the Colombian coast, Minifaldas en verano, which has received recognition at the India Catalina Awards, the most important audiovisual awards at the local level. The approach taken for each cue was to present it through the idea of modern hybridization, that is, to make it sound "cinematic" while also being able to apply this sound to an example that is not necessarily local and confirm its applicability in other contexts. Finally, the discoveries were applied to international short films with a completely contrasting context.

Desterrados

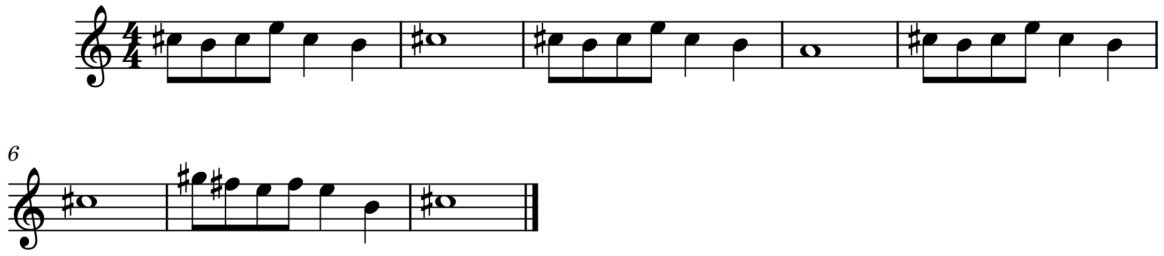
For Desterrados, we mainly used three local instruments. The most prominent are the gaita and the tiple, but we also used Colombian percussion instruments and marimba de chonta. With all our planning, we composed several pieces in which the main focal themes are forgetting, home (as a safe place), and memory.

The suite is structured around the development of two central leitmotifs: the first embodies sorrow, historical memory, and cultural roots, while the second evokes home, tranquility, and nostalgia:

Leitmotif number one (Resilience):



Leitmotif number two (Home):



M0 Prologue

This cue represents the nostalgia associated with home, from the perspective of the Exile. At the beginning, we hear the melody played on the *gaita*, reflecting the roots of the land one comes from. The melody then passes to the strings, growing into something much larger and using this motif to convey a sense of grief.

This marks the beginning of the story, which is told from the perspective of the exiled character, and it is here that the theme of resilience is heard in all its splendor. At this moment, the character sits down to recall a traumatic memory. Although the recollection is tinged with nostalgia and sadness, the theme of resilience remains predominant. Fragments of this theme will reappear in several cues before returning in full at the end of the work, with the conclusion in M8.

M1 Territory

To represent the state of uprootedness, it was necessary to create a state of calm, a sense of belonging that we called Home, the territory. This cue is created from gaita pads, over which a marimba de chonta slowly introduces the warm theme of home. The best way to express stability is through a long D pedal, over which the theme is introduced not only on the marimba but also on the tiple. At the end, a gaita sings as if a child were singing on the riverbank. The music functions as an accompaniment to a static image, almost in slow motion, where everyday life is paramount and where one can walk safely. However, the cue also places us in a position of nostalgia, as if everything being felt were an old, blurred memory.

M2 Presence

This cue represents the arrival of conflict, what comes in to take away tranquility. In this way, it is presented as a dark cue, with several textures and a fairly low register. The melody is carried by the double bass; it is a slow and heavy melody that conveys the presence that terrifies and disrupts tranquility. The key lies in the textures. Here, the gaita is not presented as a melodic instrument but is processed with reverb, pitch changes, and panning to make it quite atmospheric. Likewise, effects characteristic of the gaita are used, so despite the bass carrying the main melody, its sound provides unity and consistency in relation to the rest of the suite's cues. This is an interesting proposal because audio processing offers us not only a new timbre based on the instrument's acoustic capabilities, but also one created through hybridization itself, allowing us to generate highly distinctive and unique atmospheres.

M3 Threat

The main purpose of this cue is to trap the listener, to make them feel that leaving home is dangerous and that any false move can have fatal consequences. The place we previously understood as home is now contaminated by violence. The intention is to generate a constant sense of fear, both personal and even collective, as if an entire community were being watched and any action could put it in danger.

At the beginning, we hear a soft, distant gaita, like a warning saying, “be careful, don't go outside.” At the same time, long synthesizer sounds appear, slowly fading in and out, like soldiers patrolling the streets or people fearfully peering through their windows. Then the percussion enters and gradually begins to represent gunshots, blows, and people who have fallen.

The piece is built from a very low, restrained, suspense-filled place. The threat is present from the beginning, but we still cannot see it completely. As the cue progresses, this tension begins to grow until what had remained hidden finally appears: violence and death are no longer at a distance; now we see them before our eyes.

M4 Uprootedness

This cue closes the first act of the story and marks the moment when we hear a choir for the first time. These voices represent the souls left behind, those the character is forced to abandon, singing with the longing to continue living. In this way, the choir represents the character's rupture with their land, their community, and everything they had until then recognized as their own.

Here, we hear the theme of exile for the first and only time. It is a deeply sad melody that seeks to bring together the pain and memory of the victims of the conflict. We decided to present this motif only once because our intention is not to revictimize or appropriate the stories of those who experienced these events, but rather to make this moment a tribute and a commemorative song for the people left behind.

Alongside the choir, the gaita appears as one of the leading elements. Its first gestures are short and fragmented, almost like fractures in garments, skins, and families breaking apart, as an identity also begins to fracture. Then comes what we call the gaita's "weeping song." The intention was for it to sound like a song sung through tears, a kind of farewell without embraces.

In the background, the tiple appears and begins to anticipate movement and transition. While the choir and the gaita remain connected to what is being left behind, the tiple is the only instrument that pushes the music forward, representing the obligation to move on, even when the character is not yet prepared to do so.

M5 Transit

At this point in the story, the second act begins, and the character enters a constant journey. They move toward a place they still do not know, while the voices of their past continue to emerge around them, represented mainly by the gaitas and quenas. For the first time, we also hear a guitar, an instrument that from this point onward becomes one of the driving forces of the narrative and helps maintain that sense of movement.

This cue is built around movement that almost never stops and timbral contrasts that seek to represent the character's confusion and loss of identity. We use cumbia as the rhythmic foundation, a rhythm normally associated with celebration and collective experience. Here,

we wanted to take it somewhere else: the rhythm remains, but its celebratory spirit is gone. The movement of cumbia is now used for this stage of the protagonist's journey and transition. The character continues moving forward while everything that was once part of their community begins to feel increasingly distant.

The stereo delay also returns, a technique we had already used earlier in the work to represent displacement. The sounds move from one side to the other, leaving empty spaces behind them, as if something were constantly moving away from the character.

Around the middle of the cue, we hear the resilience theme again, first introduced in M1.5, which later becomes a fundamental part of the work's conclusion in M8. Its appearance at this point functions as an inner force that prevents the character from giving up. They are still confused, far from home, and surrounded by sounds they recognize less and less; however, something still exists within them that compels them to continue. The cue's ending leaves us in the city. We hear the guitar ostinato again, but in a different, darker, and more isolated context, preparing us for the alien concrete jungle the character will face.

M6 Non-place

This cue represents what is unfamiliar and depicts the city in an industrial and somewhat dark way. It is presented this way to show not only the transition from the countryside to the city, but also the inner feeling of being in an unfamiliar place where one is forced to live. In this sense, large cities can be portrayed as cold and dark. Extensive audio processing of Colombian instruments is used here, along with sound design, to create this industrial and unfamiliar feeling.

M7 Memory

This cue represents longing, nostalgia for home, and what has been lost. Here, the choir and orchestra are used. The cue is accompanied by the tiple and presents the melody of the “Home” theme. This melody is presented several times as it gradually builds into a crescendo that embodies the intensity of missing home. After being exiled, the desire to return home becomes much stronger. Here, a gaita solo is presented over the choir and orchestra, once again demonstrating that this nostalgia can be represented by unifying conventional instruments with the distinctive sounds of South American instruments.

M8 Inside my roots - Resilience.

Dentro de mis raíces is the cue that closes the entire narrative. At this point, we did not want to retell the sad story of uprootedness, because we had already experienced it throughout the previous cues. We wanted to end by speaking about the strength with which these people have had to move forward after losing their home, their community, and, in many cases, part of the life they knew. For this reason, this cue shares some elements with M5, through its movement and the need to move forward, while also presenting the resilience theme in its entirety. However, it also shares elements with M4, through its nostalgia and the memories that remain. It is about looking back with sadness while understanding at the same time that one must keep walking.

The musical structure takes the shape of a parabola. It begins with a very simple string texture that gradually grows until it reaches the largest point of the entire piece, with the full orchestra repeating the uprootedness theme again and again. After this climax, everything begins to disappear, and we return to the string texture with which we began.

There is something important about this ending: the string orchestra, which previously represented what was unfamiliar, has now become the foundation of the music. The character had to learn to live somewhere else, adapt, and build a new present, and so what was once strange has now also become part of them. However, their roots never disappear. Amid the orchestra, we still hear gaitas, tiples, and marimbas appearing from time to time, almost like memories of what their home once was.

We wanted this to be a heroic ending, but not because the character has triumphed or recovered everything they lost. It is heroic because, despite what happened, they managed to move forward. They built a new identity from a place that was once unfamiliar, without forgetting or leaving behind everything they still carry within them.

PEDACITO DE TELA – SHORT FILM

Technical Details

Name of the Proposal: Pedacito de Tela Duration: Between 10 and 12 minutes, including credits. Target Audience: Family. Genre / Subgenre: Social Drama.

In Pedacito de Tela, sound plays a very important role in the story. From our first conversations with the directors, we understood that elements such as fabrics, the sea, the wind, and the sounds of bullerengue had to feel alive and have a presence of their own within the film. The music had to emerge from that same world and blend with it. To achieve this, we used gaitas, processing and sampling them to create a soundscape that accompanies the protagonist's memories at the beginning of the short film. In one section, a lullaby is even played on two gaitas, alluding to the innocence of the past. Eva constantly remembers things from her past, especially her mother, but these memories never appear in a completely clear way. For this reason, we also applied a great deal of reverb and stereo delay so that the music would feel distant and diffuse in this initial section.

Another key point was the exploration of bullerengue beyond the traditional folkloric sphere. The intention was never to use bullerengue, gaitas, or percussion simply to indicate that the story takes place in the Caribbean. We wanted to draw on their sounds and some of their musical characteristics to construct Eva's emotional world. For this reason, the percussion, for example, does not necessarily have a festive character, just as it never did in the music for Desterrados.

Bullerengue enters this story in fragments and blends with female voices that seem to follow Eva's narration. Often, these are reduced to small pulses that can feel like a heartbeat or breathing. This combination of percussion and female voices gradually takes shape, beginning with several seconds of silence before developing into a clear rhythm accompanied by female voices. We did not want a leading voice that stood above the others, but rather several women singing together, sometimes even whispering or shouting. At certain moments, the voices are present, while at others they can barely be heard in the distance, almost as if the wind were carrying them in and then taking them away again.

Visually, we may find ourselves facing a beautiful, peaceful, and contemplative landscape, while beneath it lies a story marked by violence, and the music is what begins to inhabit precisely that space.

The soundtrack can breathe alongside the soundscape and draw on elements that already exist within the scene, turning them into part of the music, especially the wind in combination with the gaitas.

We also want to allow the music to remain after Eva has left the frame. This is particularly important in the moments related to her memories. The image may change or the character may disappear, but the sound continues for a few seconds, always alluding to something she has just remembered and that still lingers in her space.

We wanted to avoid excessively dramatic music that explained every emotion. For this reason, it feels more like a group playing behind the protest than the protest itself. There are scenes in which silence, the duration of a shot, or a distant sound can carry much more weight than a melody. Silence is part of the soundtrack and helps us feel the distance, emptiness, and absence that accompany Eva.

The only contrasting section occurs when a guitar appears and the image takes us to the protest. There, our intention was to musically accompany the protest's fervor, almost like the songs women tend to sing at such moments, such as Canción sin miedo.

Finally, the music brings the bullerengue cycle to a close, transforming it into an ambient texture that leads the viewer toward the conclusion of the story. Here, we can hear a piano that has not appeared at any previous point and has no connection to the territory's timbral characteristics. However, it helps narratively to emphasize the final statements and bring a sense of calm, since we have been in constant motion throughout.

Outside the Local Context

- **Warhammer 40,000 (Trailer)**

A trailer for a cyberpunk story such as Warhammer was chosen because, despite its grand industrial, post-apocalyptic animations, the story, beyond focusing on great heroes, is based on survival, misery, blind faith, and the lost state of humanity.

In your trailer, the woman who enters to hunt mutants embodies this duality: externally or internally, she still retains something of flesh and blood (the human), but her body and weapons are killing machines (the robotic).

The music was created from this duality. We asked ourselves how this human condition could coexist within such a robotic body. For this reason, a tiple and a guitar were used as the textural and rhythmic foundation, striking them, scraping them, and sampling the many extended techniques we were able to extract from the guitar. We then processed these sounds

slightly to make them sound industrial while still evoking something close to a traditional Western, with plucked strings and cowboys.

The quena was then added, providing key melodic material for identifying the trailer's leitmotif. One could say that wind instruments are the most human instruments after the voice, since they require direct breathing. The sound of air striking the wood, the imperfection of the breath, and condensation are the purest reminders that a living being is holding that instrument. Precisely because the quena performers were amateurs, we were able to find several imperfections in the performance that ultimately enhanced the humanity behind the story.

Finally, female voices were included to allude to the power of this woman and how easily she destroys the mutants. Very few electronic elements were added to all of this; most of the music was acoustic and based on these three traditional instruments.

- **Hasta que suene el timbre (Until the bell rings)**

Hasta que suene el timbre is a short film that explores the contrast between two students in a classroom: a rigorous and diligent girl and a distracted, creative classmate. From the midpoint of the story onward, the dynamic changes when they transform handmade figures into opponents in an imaginary duel. This animated sequence of action and childhood fantasy escalates in tension and rhythm until it is interrupted by the sound of the school bell.

The musical approach addresses this second half by combining the conventions of the action-adventure genre with a distinctive timbral identity. The inclusion of traditional instruments—specifically the gaita and the tambora in the percussion—provides an organic and distinctive groove, balancing the innocence of the game with the energy of the battle. This integration demonstrates how locally rooted sounds can coexist with contemporary cinematic language, working effectively in animation, dramatic fiction, or promotional formats.

Conclusions

Introduction and Overall Assessment of the Research

This research left us with several certainties that go beyond analysing theory, transcribing scores, or working in the DAW. We began with a clear and challenging question: is it possible to use local organology, rhythms, and the sounds of traditional Colombian music in cinema in a modern way, without necessarily sounding folkloric, as is often the case, and without repeating what has always been done?

Over these months, the project led us to explore historical memory and read the chronicles of the conflict in Alfredo Molano's Desterrados. We also carefully designed a hybrid sound palette. We composed a suite of eight movements, orchestrated for a large ensemble, and recorded with a mixed choir and a symphony orchestra of more than fifty musicians. In addition, we tested these ideas in audiovisual projects, both in Colombian cinema and in international scene-rescoring exercises.

1. Sound Identity

The first and most important thing we learned is that a traditional instrument does not have to be used only when the image shows the countryside, a tropical river, or a typical Colombian scene. Cinema and the media have led audiences to associate certain sounds with particular places: if a tiple is heard, we think of the Andean mountain range; if a gaita hembra or a llamador is heard, we think of the Caribbean coast; and if a marimba de chonta appears, we place ourselves in the mangroves of the Pacific region. This association may work in some documentaries or folkloric works, but when composing dramatic music for cinema, it becomes an unnecessary limitation.

When we stopped viewing these instruments solely as typical music and began using them as direct sources for acoustic hybridisation, we noticed their wooden noises, the movement of air, their harmonics, and even their apparent flaws. In this way, we discovered that they can fit into any story. During the project, we were inspired by Gustavo Santaolalla's work on The Last of Us. Santaolalla used the ronroco, an Andean string instrument, to create the music for a post-apocalyptic science-fiction world in the United States. Someone playing that video game or watching the series does not think about whether the instrument comes from Bolivia or Argentina, or whether they are listening to South American folk music. What they feel is

loneliness, loss, human fragility, and an intimate beauty amid desolation. In composing the Desterrados suite, we observed the same result. By processing a gaita or a quena with reverb, compression, delay, or distortion, the sound ceases to evoke cumbia or a traditional dance and becomes a dense psychological suspense texture, similar to any avant-garde sound design produced internationally. Likewise, the low resonances and percussive strikes on the body of a tiple or a traditional drum can serve effectively as sources of tension in a thriller, a chase sequence, or an atmosphere of mystery in an urban or futuristic setting. In contemporary audiovisual storytelling, what matters is not where the instrument comes from, but its emotional impact, colour, and dramatic contribution to the characters and the scene. This palette is highly versatile for intimate drama, suspense, horror, or science fiction because it connects with basic human emotions that do not depend on any specific place.

2. Local Audiovisual Production

For our local productions in Colombia, this approach represents a key opportunity that the industry has been seeking. If we review the history of film music in our country, we see that productions have often moved from one extreme to the other. On the one hand, there is the tendency to use traditional music directly, with complete songs or typical ensembles performing folk rhythms in the foreground. This often overloads the scene, clashes with dialogue, and limits the possibility of accompanying the psychological nuances of the story. On the other hand, some productions, in seeking to reach a supposed international standard, eliminate any trace of local identity and attempt to copy Hollywood formulas. As a result, they fill sequences with generic orchestrations from string libraries and synthesisers that sound the same as those in many foreign commercial productions.

In practice, we confirmed this through the music for short films such as Pedacito de Tela, the mock-ups for Un Castillo, and our work on the thematic development of Desterrados. There is a more solid, mature, and honest middle ground. It involves engaging directly with our cultural roots and the historical memory of our territory while using these materials through processes of modification, sound design, extended techniques, and contemporary orchestration.

Instead of using the most common forms of folk music, one can take the foundation of a 6/8 metre or the syncopation of bullerengue and dismantle them to create tension in a chase scene or convey the sadness of a family loss on screen. Colombian and regional cinema therefore

does not have to resemble foreign cinema to sound professional, nor does it have to remain confined to predictable formulas. It is possible to portray difficult subjects such as uprootedness, armed violence, resilience, or family crises with a distinct identity while maintaining the technical quality, mixing, and elegance needed to compete at any major international film festival.

3. Universal Reach

One of our main objectives was to test this language with audiences, supervisors, and projects outside Colombia to determine whether it truly worked in a global context. Academic review sessions, pitch presentations, and international rescoring tests confirmed that music and timbre can cross borders when they are well integrated into the narrative.

Currently, international film and video game markets are saturated with music created exclusively using standard commercial libraries from major software brands. Directors, producers, and music supervisors receive hundreds of mock-ups featuring the same string sounds, synthetic basses, and cinematic impact effects. For this reason, when an international director hears a proposal that uses low frequencies created from a processed traditional drum, or harmonic tension achieved through a hybrid ensemble in which a distorted tiple blends with orchestral cellos, the proposal immediately stands out.

Abroad, no one expects Latin American composers to be lesser copies of those working in the major studios of Los Angeles or London. What truly matters is originality, identity, and the ability to propose new sounds that have not yet saturated the market. By presenting this sound style in international film productions, we confirmed that audiences in other countries do not need to understand the anthropological details of Colombian music to feel something. Helplessness, silence, the force of an irregular rhythm, or the fragility of wood in high registers are universal sensations. Music makes an impact through its dramatic power and demonstrates that the local, when it has conceptual depth and its style is carefully developed, becomes the most universal language.

4. Live Performance

One of the most useful and valuable conclusions of this project was bringing our ideas from the virtual environment of the DAW into acoustic performance with real musicians. On a computer, when using synthesisers, samplers, and processing tools, almost everything seems

to work. We can raise the volume of a small instrument with a digital fader, correct its tuning with a click, and adjust frequencies precisely and easily. However, when we leave the screen and enter the recording room, the physics of sound imposes its own rules and does not tolerate orchestration errors.

During our process, we directly faced the acoustic challenges of traditional Colombian instruments. Many of these instruments do not follow the equal-tempered tuning standards of Western symphonic instruments. They present microtonal details, irregular resonances, and, above all, a volume that may be very low or very high compared with the power of a brass section or a full string orchestra. Randomly adding plugins to a mix is not enough to solve the problem.

We learned that achieving genuine hybridisation requires understanding how each traditional instrument sounds. It is necessary to know its natural dynamic range, the harmonic register in which it can stand out without being covered by the orchestral violins or woodwinds, and which extended technique can add timbral richness without forcing the musician to strain the instrument excessively. This led us to study orchestration in depth. We discovered that the space required for an indigenous texture to work within a large orchestra must be created in the score itself. Space must be left in the arrangement, and the orchestration must remain transparent rather than simply adding uncontrolled layers.

Furthermore, preparing the recording packages for orchestra and choir in Europe showed us that technical discipline is essential. Recording with real symphonic ensembles under very limited studio time does not allow for improvisation or mistakes in the scores. We created the preliminary mock-ups in the DAW, carefully wrote everything in notation software, controlled tempo curves, clicks, and dynamic markings in detail, and prepared the sessions in Pro Tools. In this way, we ensured that the artistic vision remained clear. The workflow we developed at Compositorio confirmed that artistic innovation cannot stand on its own; it requires organised and professional production to preserve the initial sonic idea from the first sketch to the final master.

5. Creative Ethics

The project's concept was based on Alfredo Molano's chronicles in Desterrados, a painful, humane, testimonial book that continually confronted us with the ethical responsibility of creating music about the suffering and uprootedness of real communities. Translating this

literary world into a poetic narrative of eight musical pieces led us to reflect deeply on the role of music in relation to violence and collective trauma.

When music is composed for subjects involving war or displacement, it is common to fall into easy melodrama. From the beginning, we understood that such a difficult subject required complete respect and a very restrained compositional approach. We discovered that a scene often carries greater weight when sound does not fill everything, but when one learns to leave space empty. Silence, long notes sustained with subtle changes in their harmonics, the dry strike of a piece of wood, or a breath suspended in the air express the uncertainty of a family forced to flee its home at night more clearly than a complicated orchestral fanfare.

The structure we created for the suite showed us that film music narratives work better when based on arcs of transformation rather than simply connecting isolated melodic themes. In the suite's first movement, centred on the territory, the music had to convey a natural sense of belonging, home, and everyday life, using clear tonal centres and an easy-to-follow pulse. Violence does not appear suddenly; instead, it is gradually introduced into the narrative through strange sounds that disrupt this acoustic stability: a metallic sound out of place, a slight dissonance, or a rhythmic change that breaks the territory's sense of security. As we move through moments of uprootedness and transition and confront the placelessness of large cities, the music gradually loses its familiar points of support and divides into cold electronic textures, industrial noises, and echoes of traditional instruments that now sound distorted, as if they were ghosts of an identity torn from its origins. This experience showed us that audiovisual composition is not about decorating images, but about creating an invisible psychological subtext that acts directly on the viewer's perception and guides them through the complexities of the narrative without stating the obvious.

6. Challenges

Recognising the limitations that arose during the research and production helps us understand the current stage of this project. We faced significant difficulties accessing traditional instruments and the people who play them. Many musicians in Colombia who master these instruments come from active oral traditions, in which music is learned and transmitted without reading Western scores or precisely following a digital click track in changing metres. This required us to be patient, conduct preliminary exploratory sessions, and adapt our working methods to teach and collaborate with them.

Another important limitation was the availability of resources and recording logistics. We managed to record the orchestra and choir in remote sessions in Europe, following international standards. When assembling solo instruments recorded in Colombia with orchestras recorded abroad, audio post-production requires great care. There are differences in room acoustics, microphone types, frequency responses, and background noise levels between a local studio and a European symphonic concert hall. Therefore, the mix must be highly detailed to ensure that the integration sounds natural rather than like layers pasted together in the DAW. These challenges do not undermine the results; instead, they clearly show which technical and methodological areas require further work in future research.

7. Future Prospects

This project is neither an endpoint nor a comprehensive treatise on film music in Colombia. We consider it a statement of principles and the formal beginning of a line of research and creative practice with considerable room to grow. The insights and lessons gathered here reveal clear paths for our professional and academic future.

First, we believe it is necessary to continue creating and recording virtual libraries of Colombian and Latin American instruments, designed specifically for film composition. Currently, the few libraries available on the international market featuring instruments from the region tend to focus on commercial tropical music patterns or fixed folkloric recordings. They do not include extended techniques, scraping, harmonics, tremolos, or articulations that generate psychological tension, which is what audiovisual composers need for their work. If software tools are designed to capture these sounds with the level of detail demanded by today's industry, more composers around the world could easily use these timbres in their productions.

Second, we see great potential in applying these techniques more extensively to interactive audio for video games. In linear cinema, each bar follows a fixed timecode. Video games, by contrast, require adaptive and nonlinear music systems that respond in real time to the player's actions and changes in the virtual environment. Bringing the hybrid textures of our instruments into interactive audio engines such as Wwise or FMOD makes it possible to design dynamic musical systems. For example, a traditional gaita melody could transform into an electroacoustic sound design when the player enters dangerous areas. This is a highly promising creative frontier that the Latin American industry is only beginning to explore.

In film and audiovisual production, the next step is to consolidate this language in fiction feature films and large-scale television series. This involves working continuously with directors and screenwriters from the earliest stages of project development. Music should not be viewed merely as the final element added during post-production, once the film is already complete. If sonic concepts and hybrid identity are addressed during scriptwriting or filming, music can influence the editing, rhythm, and very soul of the work.

7. The Human Condition

Traditional instruments can take us back to our roots and bring us closer to what is most human. This becomes striking when a story unfolds in worlds that, visually, seem far removed from our everyday lives. Works such as The Last of Us, Cyberpunk, Warhammer, and Ghost in the Shell depict dystopian, technological, or futuristic universes, yet they continue to address fundamental human themes. They speak about loss, loneliness, identity, memory, fear, and the need to belong.

In these cases, using acoustic or traditional instruments, or sounds with a certain human imperfection, can create a strong contrast with what we see on screen. Even when we see futuristic cities, machines, destroyed worlds, or technologies that do not yet exist, these sounds can bring our attention back to the character and remind us that the story is still about a person.

This idea was central to our project. We used traditional instruments not merely to place the music in a particular location or tell the viewer, “This is Colombia.” We are drawn to them because they convey closeness, memories, and human contact. This remains true even when we process these sounds, combine them with electronic elements, or place them in other contexts. In this way, a gaita, a tiple, a marimba, or a voice can connect the visual world with the character's human experience.

Final Reflection

Upon completing this research and creative project, we are convinced that contemporary composers do not have to choose between two fixed options. We do not need to remain within nostalgic nationalism or strictly copy commercial trends.

Our traditional music, our instruments, and the complex stories of our territory possess unique acoustic richness, expressiveness, and dramatic power. The challenge and commitment we undertake as creators is to develop the orchestral craft, technical rigour, and aesthetic sensitivity needed to bring these sounds into an equal dialogue with global film practices. This work demonstrates that it is indeed possible to build a solid bridge between local roots and the universal screen. It thus opens a horizon in which our sounds are not perceived through an exoticising perspective, but as a living, versatile, moving, and contemporary cinematic voice capable of telling any story anywhere in the world.

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- *Rodrigo D. No futuro* (1990) Directed by Víctor Gaviria. Colombia: Foto Club Producciones.
- *Siembra* (2015) Directed by Ángela Osorio Rojas and Santiago Lozano Álvarez. Colombia: Contravía Films.
- *Tantas almas* [Valley of Souls] (2019) Directed by Nicolás Rincón Gille. Colombia / Belgium: Medio de Contención Producciones.